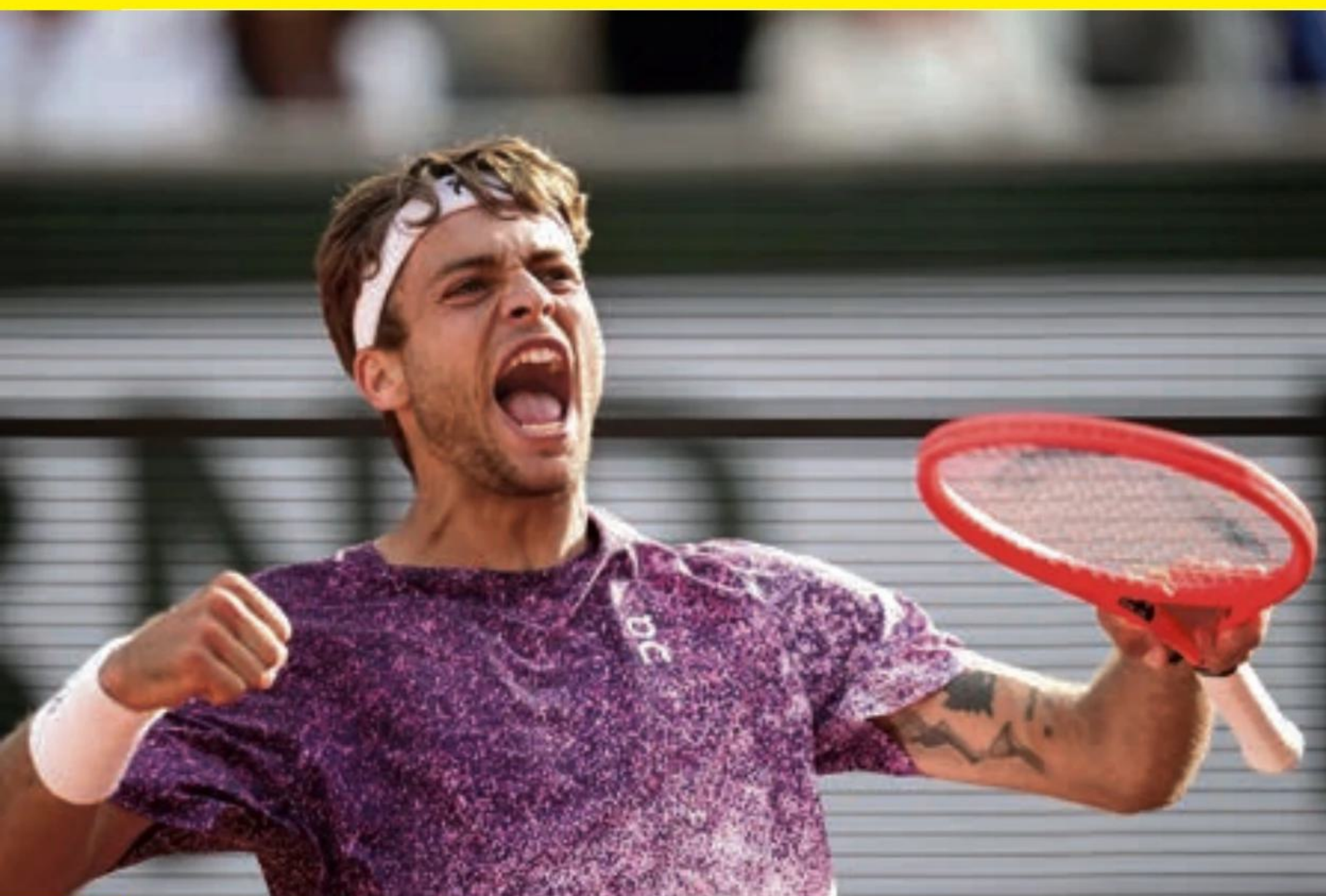




fascinating match that more than lived up to its lofty expectations. Djokovic (**below**), more than double the age of 19-year-old Brazilian hotshot Joao Fonseca, had never lost to a teenager (18-0) at a Major. Fonseca had never beaten a top-five player anywhere or reached a Major fourth round.

The Djoker surged ahead 6-4, 6-4 before the barrel-chested teenager complemented his signature rocket

forehand with effective kick serves and smart drop shots to grab the next two sets 6-3, 7-5. Despite high heat and punishing rallies, Djokovic broke serve with a backhand drop-volley winner to lead 3-1 in the deciding set. Fonseca rebounded, and when he held serve at 5-all, the exhausted Serb sat briefly on the side wall to rest.

The Brazilian broke serve for 6-5 with a deceptive forehand drop-shot winner that Djokovic didn't run for. In a last gasp to stave off defeat, the 24-time Major champion earned break point. Fonseca responded with three staccato-like aces, each over 130mph, to prevail 4-6, 4-6, 6-3, 7-5, 7-5.

Fountain of youth

Two other budding stars also excelled. Jakub Mensik, the imposing 6ft 5in power-hitter from Czechia, overwhelmed No. 8 seed Alex de Minaur in four sets, and 27th-seeded Rafael Jodar of Spain defeated Alex Michelsen in five sets.

There was also France's just-turned-17 Moise Kouame, the youngest player in the draw and the most intriguing newcomer, who lost to Alejandro Tabilo in four sets in his Grand Slam debut. Fired up by partisan spectators chanting his name, Kouame trounced former US Open champion Marin Cilic 7-6(4), 6-2, 6-1 in the first round and then

Fight to the end: Cobolli put up a great fight to take the final to five sets.

AP

outlasted Daniel Vallejo in a fifth-set match tiebreak 10-8. A born entertainer, the fist-pumping Kouame collapsed on his back on match point.

The youngest Roland Garros quarterfinal since 2006 — when Nadal, 20, defeated Djokovic, 19 — pitted Mensik, 20, against Fonseca, 19. The Czech boasted a first serve averaging 125 mph, with 40 per cent going unreturned. The Brazilian's booming forehand gave him the edge in long rallies. Their stamina would be the wild card if the match went five sets.

Mensik made sure it didn't by dictating with his huge serve, aggressive backhand, improved movement and elite touch for a convincing 6-4, 6-3, 7-6(3) triumph. Fonseca fended off six match points, but Mensik clinched the tiebreak with three winners — a smash followed by two backhands — to extend his tiebreak record to 15-5 this season.

Zverev took care of business in his quarterfinal against 'the new Rafa', 19-year-old Jodar of Spain. Some of his University of Virginia teammates flew in to support Jodar, who had racked up a 19-2 match record on clay. He delighted them when he raced to a 5-3 lead and served for the set.

But Zverev broke him to love and then seized the tiebreak 7-3 for a record 12th straight tiebreak victory. The 6ft 6in German clinched a 7-6(3), 6-1, 6-3 victory with a spectacular 105mph forehand winner from way outside the alley. His once-criticised forehand had gone from passive to massive.

Zverev was a heavy favourite against Mensik in their semifinal, even though the German hadn't won a tournament this season. He had a considerably easier draw, facing just one seed, the inexperienced No. 27 Jodar, and had spent four fewer hours on court than the brawny Czech. Two

